



Performance management in a milieu of customer participatory measurement: Beyond the ratings and rankings of *Strictly Come Dancing*

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ABSTRACT

This research concerns the performance management practices that unfolded in *Strictly Come Dancing*, a television show whose viewers were promised that they could be its co-creators through Web 2.0-based customer participatory measurement systems that directed the development of the series mechanically. Analysing the performance management practice of the 2013 Danish version of the show, we find that an emotive, antagonistic competitive language game and an authoritative, calculative language game were operating in interaction. They facilitated an expectation of consumer democracy and made viewers engage fiercely with the show, while simultaneously controlling the drama so that it would unfold in a way that matched the voice of the television company. The study provides novel insights into our understanding of how companies might produce and use customer participatory measurement systems as an integrated part of their customer participatory logic of value co-creation. It also adds to the methodological apparatus for analysing, conceptualising, and understanding organisational practices of performance management.

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1. Introduction

Increasingly, we are witnessing the evolution of a participatory culture, where private individuals are free to engage in the creation and production of the cultural and organisational products and services they consume (Blank & Reisdorf, 2012; Fuchs, 2014; Jenkins, 2005). The end user participatory approach has been made possible by the participatory Web, also known as Web 2.0 or the social Web, which offers an open, interactive, and system-interoperable information platform where end users can easily generate content (text, symbols, images, graphics, videos, or audio) and exchange experiences, views, and ideas with the organisation and with each other (Jenkins, 2005).

In a business context, a customer participatory logic of value co-creation is emerging, which implies that companies are opening up their processes to be influenced by end users, whom companies use as co-creators, producers, or prosumers (i.e., professional consumers) of their products and services (Prahalad & Ramaswamy, 2004, p. 8). A customer participatory logic embraces end users bringing content into organisational processes at different inventional levels (van Dijck, 2009). End users

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can have their say not only about products and services for their own consumption, but also about products and services for everyone else's consumption. End users engaged in value creation do not receive any wages; in order to maintain their motivation, they must believe that their participation will be valued in some way (Jenkins, 2005). Consequently, companies embracing a customer participatory approach are faced with intercustomer dependency in their creation of customer value and a new form of interdependency in their customer relationships. Therefore, they need to develop new performance management practices for the creation of products and services of mutually beneficial value in a situation of complex goal interdependencies (Antorini, Muniz, & Askildsen, 2012). We consider performance management to include (non)calculative techniques for organisational planning and control and certain epistemic methods through which these techniques are produced and used (Arbnor & Bjerke, 1997; H. Nørreklit, 2017a).

Companies might use the participatory Web to produce customer ratings and rankings for their decision-making in product and service ideas and design characteristics. Different epistemic methods are on hand for applying such customer participatory measurement (Arbnor & Bjerke, 1997). For instance, organisational managers might apply the measurement in interplay with their reflective judgements, which furthers their control over decision-making about product design and hence over the characteristics of its brand (H. Nørreklit, 2017a). In contrast, *Strictly Come Dancing*, the reality-television talent programme of British origin, uses customer participatory ratings and rankings mechanically to give the calculated output a direct influence on the content of the broadcast. This paper aims to provide insight into the mechanical epistemic practice of customer participatory performance measurement as embodied in the case of *Strictly Come Dancing*.

More specifically, *Strictly Come Dancing* is a combined entertainment show and dance competition built around the story of transforming a layperson into a dance star who wins the competition. The overall format of the programme originated with the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) but is licensed by other television channels, which have adapted the format for different times and different locations around the world. In the 2013 Danish version of *Strictly Come Dancing* (in Danish: *Vild med Dans*),¹ broadcast on the largest Danish commercial television channel, TV2, twelve pairs of dancers, each consisting of a professional dancer and a celebrity amateur dancer, competed against each other. The non-professional dancers were cast by the television company to ensure the show would feature interesting characters (i.e., 'princesses', 'princes', 'jesters', and 'fools') and offer a 'happy ending' drama for a character who displayed some dancing ability and glamour, in alignment with the identifying marks of the programme (Bonner, 2013; Enli, 2009). The winners of the competition have been very diverse, however, and maintaining the right balance of entertainment and professional content is considered important for controlling the brand and retaining the majority of the audience (Bonner, 2013).

During the show, four professional judges make verbal comments and award points on a scale from one to ten for the dancing couples' performances in terms of the art of dance. These scores are used to calculate and display the judges' ranking of the couples. After the judges have awarded their points, viewers are invited to influence the outcome of the show by using TV2's social media platforms and SMS voting system. The points awarded by viewers through SMS votes are used to calculate the viewers' ranking. The two rankings are then added together to classify the pairs of dancers in an overall ranking. This ranking determines which couples will continue directly to the next episode of the series and which (the two lowest-ranked pairs) will enter a 'dance-off' elimination round in which only viewers' votes determine who will continue to take part. Thus, the television company uses the rankings in ways that are disconnected from management's situational knowledge and reflective judgement; superficially, it appears that the development of the programme is in the hands of the viewers via the customer participatory calculation system.

In the 2013 Danish version of the programme, the result of the customer participatory measurement system was that the well-known 60-year-old ex-footballer Allan Simonsen (European Footballer of the Year 1977) reached the semi-final, despite receiving the lowest score ever from the judges. It is unusual for the 'sore thumb' of the show to get beyond the halfway point in the series (Bonner, 2013), and this result gave rise to an extraordinary level of argument on social media.² Surprisingly, more than halfway into the show's run, TV2 changed the SMS voting rules, which involved a change in established procedures and required the approval of the licence owners (the BBC).

Against this background, we considered what techniques and epistemic methods might be used in the case of *Strictly Come Dancing* to deal with the performance management puzzle of goal conflicts, and how viewers might become co-creators of the show. This paper therefore scrutinises the following research questions in relation to the 2013 Danish edition of *Strictly Come Dancing*:

- (i) By means of which techniques and epistemic methods did the TV2 television channel strive to engage viewers to participate in the show while simultaneously aiming to ensure that the winner was in line with the identifying marks of the *Strictly Come Dancing* brand?
- (ii) What type of co-creating viewers was the TV2 customer participatory approach able to embrace?

Drawing on the philosophy of language games (Wittgenstein, 1953) and the theory of pragmatic constructivism (L. Nørreklit, 2017b; Nørreklit, Nørreklit, & Mitchell, 2016), we found that an emotive, antagonistic competitive language game and an authoritative, calculative language game in combination ran the customer participative measurement practice of TV2.

¹ <http://omtv2.tv2.dk/index.php?id=6980>.

² See <http://vmd.tv2.dk/2013-09-28-tv-2-chef-om-kritik-det-er-seerne-der-bestemmer>.

These language games created an expectation of consumer democracy and encouraged viewers to engage in producing information input for the show, while simultaneously allowing TV2 to control the drama so that it would unfold in a way that matched the channel's voice. Some viewers were able to undermine the TV2-projected drama of the show by making 'phantom' viewers cast votes for the 'sore thumb' of the show, Allan. However, TV2 could not embrace the winner created by these viewers, and it changed the calculation system to produce an ending consistent with the identifying marks of the programme.

The investigation is relevant as it contributes to our understanding of how companies might produce and use customer participatory measurement systems as an integrated part of their customer participatory logic of value co-creation. Accounting research has investigated the characteristics and effects of TripAdvisor's traveller ratings and reviews of hotels and restaurants (Jeacle & Carter, 2011; Scott & Orlikowski, 2012); however, as TripAdvisor's customer participatory measurement platform was produced and developed outside the control of the hotels and restaurants, it is not an integrated part of their customer participatory logic of value co-creation. There are also a number of studies on *Strictly Come Dancing* (Bonner, 2013; Enli, 2009), but these do not focus on the participatory measurement system. To the best of our knowledge, the production and use of customer participatory measurement in such a context has not yet been investigated in the literature.

As the relevant communications are made public on television and on social media, a talent reality show such as *Strictly Come Dancing* provides a unique case for providing direct insight into the production and use of customer participatory measurement systems. Our study is further justified on the grounds that many other organisations appear to use customer participatory measurement models mechanically, even if their production and use of ratings and rankings are not made public.

Additionally, drawing on the philosophy of language games (Wittgenstein, 1953) and the paradigm of pragmatic constructivism (L. Nørreklit, 2017b) to conceptualise how 'actors' organise their everyday practices to create intentional outcomes, our study adds to the methodological apparatus for analysing, conceptualising, and understanding organisational practices of performance management in a participatory business context. The paper extends the toolkit of performance management by revealing the techniques and methods used within an emotive competitive language game and an authoritative calculative language game, and identifying how these might operate in cooperation for organisational control in a user participatory context.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. First, we outline the theoretical and methodological basis of our analysis and research questions. We then conduct an analysis of the language games of performance management that run the customer participatory measurement practice of *Strictly Come Dancing* and the types of co-creating viewers engaged with the show. Finally, we discuss our findings and draw conclusions.

2. Theory and method

This section explains the theoretical foundation of our research, which gives rise to our conceptualisation of our research questions, our approach to investigating these questions, and our selection of texts for analysis.

2.1. Theoretical framework

Aiming to understand an organisation's practice of performance management and ways in which viewers can be co-creators, we draw on the philosophy of language games developed by Wittgenstein (1953) and the paradigm of pragmatic constructivism (L. Nørreklit, 2017b; Nørreklit et al., 2016) to conceptualise how 'actors' organise their everyday practices to create intentional results. Finally, we outline some general language games of performance management and of being a co-creator.

2.1.1. Language games of everyday practices

The later elements of Wittgenstein's work (1953) question the realist paradigm that the meaning of a sign is apparent only through its reference to a specific thing which permits people to name it (e.g., Wittgenstein, 1961 [1921] in his earlier work). Wittgenstein argues that to understand the meaning of a sign, one should look at how language is learned and used in daily human activities. More specifically, in his later work Wittgenstein (1953) shows that people use language in everyday practice not only to refer to things but also to spur intentional action within specific areas of activity. Accordingly, humans construct and organise their everyday practices around the use of a more or less complex set of language games. In this context, a language game is the entirety of the language and the activity into which it is woven. A classic example of a simple micro-language game is the 'builder's language', which consists of the words 'block', 'pillar', 'slab', etc. The builder calls out these words to get the items he needs, and the assistant fetches them in response (Wittgenstein, 1953, §2).

This bringing together of human saying and doing is demonstrated in Austin's (1962) work on speech acts, which argues that human talk is loaded with performativity because it has communicative intent in relation to one's own actions and those of others, and as such performs an action (i.e., a speech act). Austin reveals that not only performative utterances ('bring me some stones') but also constative utterances ('we have 100 stones') have communicative intent and therefore perform a type of action. The *locution* is the content of an utterance, while the *illocution* is the sender's emphasis on the request for action (on the part of the sender or of another person) when saying something. Utterances that state things and utterances that order actions express different degrees of request for action; that is, different illocutionary forces.

However, many language games are more open to new rules than the speech acts illustrated by Austin. In organising their practices, people do not limit themselves to following language games with established language rules; they generate new types of language games through language play (Nørreklit et al., 2016). In language play, human beings are innovative, creating new rules and making new language games possible. Some practices are run mainly by closed language games, while openness to play is crucial for other practices.

When we pay attention to the type of language that is used, we also call to mind images of a certain field of practice and how it is organised and controlled (Wittgenstein, 1953, §23). The reason is that language is like a toolbox containing a multitude of words that can be put together in numerous forms of utterance serving various functions. The specific type of language use (e.g., utterances, semantics, images, grammar, or arguments) in a set of language games is bound together with a certain form of social practice, or, in Wittgenstein's terms, forms of life. Although there are language conventions for the use of words, the specific meaning of language is linked to the social practices within which it is learned, used, and developed. For instance, the meaning of words such as 'block', 'pillar', and 'slab' must be found in their use within a specific practice and cannot be deciphered in the context of a purely referential understanding of language. Likewise, numbers are symbols that acquire meaning not from their references but through their use according to certain rules. The rules of numbers acquire meaning in relation to their use in specific activities, as in the builder example in relation to counting the number of stones, calculating the need for stones, measuring their size and weight, categorising their qualities, and so on. To understand the meanings of numbers, we need to know not only the rules for the numbers in our toolbox but also what we are counting, what we are counting it for, and how these numbers will be used.

2.1.2. Conditions for creating intentional results

Wittgenstein (1953) illustrates the notion of language games by abstracting from social, human, material, and linguistic conditions. However, people are actors who act not in a void but in the world of human life, constructing their relationships to the physical, biological, human, and social phenomena of the world (Nørreklit et al., 2016; L. Nørreklit, 2017b). As soon as we have a communication from which we expect a result, we have a language game. However, if the appropriate circumstances are not in place, the language game might not lead to the intended result.

Specifically, pragmatic constructivism contends that for the actor's language construction to function pragmatically (i.e., to create intentional effects in practice), the following four dimensions of reality have to be integrated: communication, possibilities, facts, and values (Nørreklit et al., 2016; L. Nørreklit, 2017b). If the actor's communication that organises the activities of the language game is to deliver the intended message, it must not only be trustworthy and understandable by the receivers, but also factually possible and within their value range. Pragmatic constructivism considers the type of successful communication illustrated in Wittgensteinian language games as manifesting such integration. More specifically, the communication carried out by Builder A calling for building blocks opens up various possible actions for Builder B in bringing the stones (e.g., walking or driving to pick them up). For the specifically outlined possibility to be more than imaginary to the receiver, the call must be grounded in the facts at hand; so, for instance, there should be stones and other material available, and there must also be institutional and individual ability to transport the stones. Furthermore, for the receivers to undertake the required activities, the sender's communication must link to their motivational values. Therefore, not only are the sender's communication and actions driven by his/her values, but for other actors to engage in the construction of a functioning relationship with the world, the construct also has to integrate their subjective values (Nørreklit, 2017a,b; Nørreklit et al., 2016).

When the senders' communication expresses factual possibilities that form a bridge between their own intentional values and those of the receivers, then their requests for intentional action will be realised. As an organisation involves multiple interconnected and specialised language games, an integration of the four dimensions has to be achieved for each activity in interaction with other activities. In consequence, establishing cooperation among organisational activities presupposes that the local actors are involved in co-authoring the communication that organises the activities of their language games.

2.1.3. Conceptualising performance management and co-creators

Organisational practices are run using a multiplicity of techniques and methods. Language is enacted and developed in local practices, and no collective language games remain unchanged across space or over time. Nevertheless, language games can be categorised according to their family resemblances with other practice fields or conceptual frameworks (Wittgenstein, 1953). As a consequence, when analysing people's specific uses of language (i.e., semantics, grammar, and argumentation), we can identify the subject matters and goals (intentional values) of their practices and what techniques and methods of performance management are running them (see, e.g., Fairclough, 2003; Ricoeur, 1984).

According to pragmatic constructivism, however, a performance management practice is not to be understood only by identifying its techniques and methods; the effectiveness of these techniques and methods in the construction of functioning practices must also be understood. To create effective organisational practices, it is vital for organisational managers to develop sound epistemic performance management methods that can integrate the four dimensions of reality construction. Therefore, when categorising an organisation's method of performance management, one should reflect upon its way of engaging with the four dimensions of reality and its pragmatic outcome, and thereby also with its ability to include the other actors as co-authors of their activities (H. Nørreklit, 2017a).

Developing organisational practices that integrate the four dimensions of reality requires the organisational manager to enter into a performance management practice drawing on an epistemic method of interactive and reflective reasoning (H. Nørreklit, 2017a). Such methods involve dialogical interaction between the actors involved and the development of an

understanding anchored in a cognitive conceptual model that has ties with the phenomena of the world. It follows that an interactive and reflective epistemic method combines the communicative activities of language play and language games. The actors are not only followers of language games created by others; they are also co-authors of the language games that run their practices and, hence, co-creators of these practices.

Managers may use emotion-induced language games that employ exclamatory, ambiguous language and ad hoc argumentation, as opposed to criterion-based language (Cassirer, 1962).³ An emotive language game is vague and incongruous, but it can create a feeling of human connection to the various phenomena of the world. It can mobilise people's motivational values to engage in the language game with a view to constructing their wishes for the outcome, although it is unclear whether their engagement will lead to the desired outcome. Emotion-infused language games can produce images of co-authorship, which may be perceived as authentic, but in fact actions may be driven by language games that operate out of sight (Cassirer, 1962).

In contrast, more authoritative language games of performance management are univocal, involving a monological voice and rigid, rule-built language systems (Bakhtin, 1981). An authoritative management language game does not integrate the values of the other, but it might integrate factual possibilities and impose strong constraints on the other's action. In such a case, there is no co-authorship or co-creation. Actors adapt to and align with existing organisational values and structures (i.e., they are followers of language games). However, if their values are not integrated into the organisational language games, they may engage in other language games that are dysfunctional for the organisation.

2.2. Conceptualisation of the research questions

We now address our research questions on the performance management practices and types of creating viewers of *Strictly Come Dancing* through the network of micro-language games producing the customer participatory measurement system that directs the development of the show. Below, we explain this network of language games of performance management and how the language games can be analysed.

2.2.1. Language games of performance management

Strictly Come Dancing is co-produced by a coalition of actors through a sequence of more or less tightly connected micro-language games. These games govern the construction of the show and the string of episodic interventions that create the move from the show's starting point to its ending. TV2 carries out performance management at both the operational level and the management level.

Besides the pairs of dancers, the dominant groups of actors involved at the operational level in the construction of the show through language games are the judges and the programme presenters (on the company side), and the viewers (on the customer side). Through their language games, which unfold during a string of episodic interventions, the judges and presenters express TV2's requests for the show (i.e., their goals) and its use of performance management techniques and methods to create the development of the series. Similarly, the viewers express their requests and ways of being co-creators of the show through their language game, which also unfolds over the course of the series.

At the management level, the BBC shapes the show format, including the circle of celebrity characters and the participatory measurement model, while the dancing characters are cast by TV2 (Bonner, 2013). The characters' language games create the pre-configuration of circumstances from which TV2 aims to construct a storyline. We do not have direct access to the communication regarding the BBC show format and TV2's casting of the pairs, but we can see the outcome of these performance management processes in the network of language games unfolding around the two introductory episodes, in which each pair of dancers delivered their first performance and the presenters explained the measurement system, inviting the viewers to engage in SMS voting and on its social media platform.⁴

With these language games of performance management, TV2 projects an expectation as to the development of the series and the possibilities for viewers to be creators of the show. However, if the appropriate circumstances regarding viewers' actual engagement are not in place, the projected ending is at stake. In this case, the language game employed by TV2 when acting on such non-intentional development showed the boundaries of the type of creating viewers that can be embraced in the participatory approach.

2.2.2. Analysis of language games and research questions

The meanings of the customer participatory measurement produced by the viewers' SMS votes, the judges' scoring, and the TV2-governed ranking algorithm are made apparent not by reference to existing states of affairs but in their practical production and use by actors requesting actions aimed at producing specific results. In particular, we can access the language games of the TV2 judges through their comments made during the episodes of the show and the language games employed by viewers on the Facebook pages related to the programme. In their communication in relation to the production of measures, these actors say something about the genre of show they are requesting and the techniques and methods through which they aim to obtain what they are requesting. We can also see the language game embedded in the calculative

³ The concept of the emotive language game is informed by Cassirer's (1962) work on symbolic forms of myth.

⁴ <http://omtv2.tv2.dk/index.php?id=6980>.

measurement tool through the programme presenters' communication in the introductory episodes and on the TV2 Facebook pages. Finally, we can follow the pragmatic effects of the language games.

By analysing the construction of the show in the two introductory episodes, we can identify the judges' and viewers' requests for the show from their communication around the technical aspects of the dance in question (the steps, body shapes, and reflections of the rhythm), the artistic elements (costumes, accessories, and artistic impression), and the personalities of the celebrity dancers (professionalism and personal character) (Moore & Richardson, 2002). The way the actors employ language (vocabulary, metaphors, modality, etc.) in their comments in these three categories is an expression of their requests in terms of whether the genre of the TV show is to be one with professional technical and artistic content or one of poor-quality entertainment (locution), and whether the request is disputable (illocution). The requests of this coalition of actors shape the latent goal conflicts embedded in the construction of the storyline of the show.

Furthermore, in the introductory episodes, we can scrutinise the underlying rationale of the customer participatory measurement technique that directs the development of the programme. The language game running the calculative system encompasses not only the algorithm of the measurement system but also TV2's method of interacting with its own intentional values and objectives and those of the participating viewers that drive their requests. An analysis of the communication constructing the calculative system can reveal whether the underlying epistemic method employs an emotional, reasonable, and/or authoritative language game to create intentional results, and hence how it aims to take into account the values of the participating viewers that drive their requests.

Additionally, by analysing the judges' and programme presenters' use of language (vocabulary, metaphors, narratives, modality, etc.) in their comments during the string of episodic interventions, we can identify the techniques and epistemic methods they draw on to create their desired direction of the show, and hence how they aim to integrate their own values and those of the viewers. Likewise, analysis of viewers' communication on social media gives access to the language game by which they act to influence the development of the series. In particular, we can identify whether they are following the rules of the TV2 language games or engaging in language play to become co-authors of new content for the show. Lastly, by analysing the action of TV2's language game on the outcomes of the customer participatory measurement system, we can see what types of creating viewers TV2 allowed for.

Accordingly, our investigation of TV2's language games of performance management techniques and epistemic methods and of their types of creating viewers allowed for will answer our first and second research questions, respectively.

2.3. Selection of texts for analysis

To support the analysis of TV2's requests for a show and performance management techniques and methods, we watched the entire series of shows and noted the judges' comments on the dancers, the rules of the participatory measurement system, and the critical moments during the shows. We selected the judges' comments on all the dancing pairs and the measurement rules from the first two and the last three episodes for more detailed analysis. We focused mainly on the comments about one celebrity dancer, Allan Simonsen, who played a key role in the development of the show and in the voting system being changed for the ninth episode. We transcribed these comments and conducted a textual analysis of them, after which we rewatched the show to evaluate whether we might have omitted some comments of importance for our analysis. Additionally, we followed the programme managers' communication around the participatory system on the TV2 Facebook page at the beginning of the show and in relation to the critical moments.

Similarly, to inform our analysis of the intentions and reactions of the viewers in relation to the way they cast their votes, we considered the Facebook pages related to *Strictly Come Dancing* and chose examples of some of the dominant views during the main stages of the series. We collected around 200 pages of text and picked 50 comments for further analysis, following which we looked through the text again to check whether we had overlooked any key comments.

Our analysis of exemplars of utterances by the main actors through the chosen media identifies the various types of language games driving the customer participatory measurement practice of *Strictly Come Dancing*. In the presentation of our findings below, we have chosen examples that most clearly illustrate the various types of actors' requests.

3. Analysis of *Strictly Come Dancing* customer participatory performance management practices

We focus first on the language games embedded in the actors' requests for the show and the language game of the TV2 calculative measurement model, as visible in the two introductory episodes of the show, which frame the formation of the storyline. These language games exhibit the techniques and methods of participatory performance measurement at the management level. Subsequently, we present the language games employed by these same actors in their intentional actions in moving from the formation of the show to its ending. Increasingly, throughout the series, the judges and viewers required the remaining dancers to be in line with their requests for the show, and conflict around Allan's continued presence increased. We reveal how the judges and viewers engaged in mobbing midway through the show, how some viewers changed the method of mobbing by ganging up through alternative social Web platforms, and how TV2 responded with an ad hoc ruling. Accordingly, this analysis provides insight into the techniques and methods of participatory performance measurement at the operational level, and what type of viewers the TV2 customer participatory approach was able to embrace. Taken as a whole, the textual analysis provides the basis for conclusions about the language games of performance management that governed

TV2's participatory practice in terms of what types of techniques and epistemic methods this practice involved, and what creating viewers TV2 could embrace. In this way, we are able to answer our two research questions.

3.1. Formation of the actors' requests for the show

In this section, we describe the type of show that the TV2 judges and customers demanded at the outset, and the strength that marked their particular requests.

3.1.1. The judges' requests

When the professional judges evaluated the dances in the first round of the series (Episode 1, September 13, 2013, and Episode 2, September 20, 2013), they emphasised the technical aspects of the dance related to footwork, body shape, and rhythm, as is evident from the prevalence of nouns such as *heel*, *main leg*, *head*, *shoulders*, and *movement*. The norm of what the dance involves was expressed through prescriptive imperatives of what to do and what not to do: *Your foot must have a heel on one, but actually no heel in so many other places*. The notion that certain technical aspects of the dance are essential prerequisites was revealed in the frequent use of the modal verb *must* and the negation *does not*.

There were also comments on the artistic dimensions of the dancers' performances in the form of costumes and physical appearance. The judges used metaphors to convey their impressions of the dancers' artistic performances: [the] *princess dream you were living out; you were a romantic couple; his name is not Mathias – call him Clark Gable. With that little moustache and everything, you look amazing*. Such metaphors connote romanticism and the artistic genre of the specific dance (in this case, the waltz). In other observations, the celebrity dancers' body conformation and appearance were described in superlatives: *pretty, handsome pair; long legs; body looks delicious*. The terms all relate to aspects of the human body that are linked to attractiveness and convey the image of an attractive, even sexy, person. In addition, the judges alluded to aspects of the celebrity dancers' professions. For example, one judge's assessment of the ex-footballer Allan's dancing performance included a reference to seeing a *loving, wonderful parody* of him in an entertainment show. The allusion to parody was used to sketch him as a comic character, despite his great footballing achievements.

To summarise, on the basis of their professional status, the judges made undisputable demands for the celebrity dancers to achieve a certain level of technical dancing skill, and emotion-driven demands for a romantic and attractive artistic appearance and character.

3.1.2. The viewers' requests

Our analysis of the language games of the viewers on the official Facebook site during the first episodes identified two main genres of request: those concerning a dancing programme and those concerning an entertainment programme.

One group of viewers required, like the TV2 judges, technically skilled dancing and attractive artistic and personal appearance in the show. However, unlike the judges, the viewers did not address specific technical abilities but made broad statements to the effect that particular dancers could not dance. For instance, *He (Allan) must leave the show next time. He does not have any sense of rhythm in his body* (Nielsen, 21 September). The opinion is bolstered by the use of phrases such as *no sense of rhythm, not ... any sense*. The modal verbs *must* articulate an authoritative stress on the requests to make those who cannot dance leave the show. Like the judges, this group requested an image of romance and physical attractiveness in the celebrity dancers' appearance, as illustrated in the following quotes by the terms *beautiful dance* and *beautiful old movie*: *Definitely, Mie and Mathias danced the most beautiful dance and looked like two [characters] from a beautiful old movie!* (Jensen, 15 September).

Another group of viewers opposed the above view and made the authoritative claim that the show is not about professional dancing but is entertainment: *it is ... an entertainment programme, NOT a professional dance competition. If you want to see professional dancers, then switch to a sports programme* (Christensen, 28 September). This group of viewers seemed to value Allan's personality, which was characterised as being *cool, wonderful, and sympathetic*: *Yes, there were things that failed, but cool appearance and a wonderful and sympathetic couple* (Timmermann, 21 September). This group of viewers had a more relaxed approach to the technical and artistic expression of the dance. However, the suggestion that viewers who wanted to see a dance competition should leave indicates that their attitude towards their requests for the show was less relaxed.

3.1.3. Conclusion: actors' requests

In conclusion, participation was established around three groups of actors expressing divergent requests. Notably, the appreciation of Allan by one group of viewers contrasted with the appreciation of a technical and artistic dance performance request on the part of the TV2 judges and the other group of viewers. Moreover, the different groups of actors did not show any willingness to accept deviations from their own perceptions of the acceptable norms for the show. Accordingly, a coalition of conflicting values was established that would drive the development of the show. The coalition of values exposes TV2's casting of the pairs around divergent requests of two groups of viewers that makes up a vital component of its customer participatory measurement approach. As shall be further explained in the following, this approach is cohesively interlinked with the way the calculative measurement model was constructed.

3.2. Formation of the calculative measurement model

The participatory measurement system of *Strictly Come Dancing* was organised around the data input produced by the judges' scores and the number of viewer SMS votes, and the measurement algorithm.

3.2.1. Judges' scores and viewers' SMS voting

To a certain extent, the scores given by the professional judges on a scale from one to ten reflected whether the couple's performance was good or bad according to the judges' standards. As revealed above, however, the judges' communication was dominated by emotional expressions, even though they also demonstrated technical and artistic expert knowledge. In fact, the judges' scores generated considerable emotional force in terms of their requests as to which couples should continue in the show and which should be dropped.

For the participatory customers, a range-voting system was applied: viewers assigned points to their preferred pairs through the number of SMS votes they cast for the pair they wanted to see in the next episode. The invitation to vote was phrased as a hypothetical imperative statement along the following lines: 'If we are to see this contestant next week, you will need to cast SMS votes for him/her'. Overall, the voting system gave the impression of being a consumer democracy. This was reinforced by the TV2 manager of *Strictly Come Dancing*, who emphasised that the show was *made for viewers* and that *it is the viewers who decide* who should continue on the show.⁵ Sending one message cost five Danish kroner. The more text votes a viewer paid for, the more influence that viewer would exert. The SMS voting system was easily accessible and did not require much reflection on the part of viewers. As revealed above, the viewers' SMS votes were exclamatory expressions of emotion-driven requests.

3.2.2. The algorithm

The measurement algorithm created a ranking that was used in a comparative assessment to establish the best, the one who surpassed all others. It was constructed by adding together the judges' ranking, generated from the scores they awarded, and the viewers' ranking, generated from the number of SMS votes cast. If the rankings were tied, the viewers' votes took precedence over the judges' scores. For example, if the judges' ranking was A:1, B:2, C:3 and the viewers' ranking was A:3, B:2, C:1, the pairs would be ranked equally (A:2, B:2, and C:2) according to the algorithm, but the viewers' ranking would then be preferred. Essentially, the algorithm aggregated and ranked numbers in line with what the TV2 judges thought the show should offer and what the aggregate of viewers demanded. This mix of ratings produced a ranking that determined which pairs would be in the next episode of the show and which would not. The development of the series was thus governed by a language game that involved excluding, one by one, all but the best pairs in the ranking (Nørreklit, 2013).

The SMS voting system and calculative ranking system exemplify a competitive customer environment organised around the format of an auction model (Levin, 2004). There was one object to be sold: the content of what should be the service features of a television programme at a particular place and time. TV2's selection of celebrities for the show appealed to a variety of viewers with conflicting values, and this constituted the competitive environment. There were many bidders (i.e., viewers) with different, analytically independent value functions for what the show should include at a particular place and time, and incomplete information about the value functions of the other bidders. The set of auction rules formulated through the measurement system gave rise to a competitive game between the viewers that was in the economic interest of the company. The group of viewers who submitted the highest bid achieved their objective, but all viewers took part in the voting, including those who did not achieve their objective. In such a situation, there is an economic incentive embedded in making customers with conflicting interests compete against each other through voting and calculative ranking systems. When at least two groups of viewers want the final 'lot', there is a market driving up the price, and hence the calculative system seems to be driven by economic thinking. More subtly, the competitive game is based on an affective mode of emotion, which relates to the experience of affect (joy, anger, etc.) that arises as a result of the frustration or satisfaction of needs and values (Heron, 1992). Thus, when a viewer's values are realised it can give rise to emotive feelings of joy, but when the values are not realised it can create frustration and anger (Heron, 1992; L. Nørreklit, 2017b). Such emotions may have fuelled viewer engagement with the show.

Furthermore, the ranking produced by the judges was weighted as half of the scoring, which implied that TV2 was the foremost bidder and that the judges' requests were likely to dominate the development of the series. As illustrated in Table 1, however, if Allan was last in the judges' ranking but first in the viewers' ranking, then he would not have been in the dance-off before the semi-finals; he would have been ranked fourth in Episodes 6 and 7, third in Episodes 8 and 9, and second in Episode 10 and the semi-final. Alternatively, if Allan had been second or third in the viewers' ranking, he would not have been in the dance-off until the third or fourth episode from the end (Episode 9 or 10).

3.2.3. Conclusion: the calculative measurement model

Strictly Come Dancing promised that viewers would have an influence on the development of the series through SMS voting, suggesting that a consumer democracy would run the development of the show. Components of the customer participatory measurement model included quantitative rating techniques and rankings of subjective values and views that

⁵ See <http://vmd.tv2.dk/2013-09-28-tv-2-chef-om-kritik-det-er-seerne-der-bestemmer>.

Table 1

The development of the show if Allan is last in the judges' ranking, but first in the viewers' ranking.

Ranking Episode 6 Pairs left: 8			Ranking Episode 7 Pairs left: 7			Ranking Episode 8 Pairs left: 6			Ranking Episode 9 Pairs left: 5			Ranking Episode 10 Pairs left: 4			Ranking Semi-final Pairs left: 3			Ranking the Final Pairs left: 2		
Jud- ges	View- ers	Weigh- ted	Jud- ges	View- ers	Weigh- ted	Jud- ges	View- ers	Weigh- ted	Jud- ges	View- ers	Weigh- ted	Jud- ges	View- ers	Weigh- ted	Jud- ges	View- ers	Weigh- ted	Jud- ges	View- ers	Weigh- ted
1	2	1.5	1	2	1.5	1	2	1.5	1	2	1.5	1	2	1.5	1	2	1.5	1	2	1.5
2	3	2.5	2	3	2.5	2	3	2.5	2	3	2.5	2	3	2.5 O	2	3	2.5 O	2 A	1 A	1.5 A
3	4	3.5	3	4	3.5	3	4	3.5	3	4	3.5 O	3	4	3.5 O	3 A	1 A	2 A, O			
4	5	4.5	4	5	4.5	4	5	4.5 O	4	5	4.5 O	4 A	1 A	2.5 A						
5	6	5.5	5	6	5.5 O	5	6	5.5 O	5 A	1 A	3 A									
6	7	6.5 O	6	7	6.5 O	6 A	1 A	3.5 A												
7	8	7.5 O	7 A	1 A	4 A															
8 A	1 A	4.5 A																		

O: In the dance off.**A:** Allan's position; Allan is considered to be last in the judges' ranking and first in the viewers' ranking.

were configured around an auction model directed by an algorithm embedded with bias. The formation of divergent, emotion-driven viewer requests were in fierce competition, as the calculative system ranking these was driven by an auction model that excluded, one by one, all but the first request in the ranking. Despite the prospect of many viewers' requests being excluded in the course of the series, the competition in itself might link to viewers' values by activating emotions of frustration and excitement, and hence engagement. Accordingly, the formation of the show was constructed by an emotive, antagonistic competitive language game embedded with latent conflicts among the emotion-driven requests of the participating actors. However, since TV2 had a greater weighting in the results, it was likely to be able to control the final outcome of the series. Thus, simultaneously with the emotive, antagonistic competitive language game, an authoritative, calculative language game carried out a meaning structure that steered the story towards the interests of TV2.

3.3. Creating intentional outcomes through mobbing on the TV2 social web

Below, we describe how TV2 judges and viewers engaged in the language game of mobbing to obtain the outcomes they wanted. Mobbing involves a crowd of people ganging up to suppress an individual or to force that person out of the group through continuous and relentless attacks, involving, for instance, belittling, intimidating, humiliating, or blaming (Davenport, Schwartz, & Elliott, 1999).

3.3.1. Judges engaging in language games of mobbing

In their comments, the judges praised those they marked highly, while they engaged in mobbing those they wanted out of the show. To obtain what they required, the judges engaged in humiliating Allan and apportioning blame to him.

As early as Episode 1, we saw attempts by the judges to make Allan and certain other dancers look ludicrous. The aggressive tone intensified, reaching its peak in the middle of the series, but then almost disappearing in subsequent episodes. In Episode 5, in particular, the judges made very aggressive comments relating to Allan's physical qualities and personal character. Examples include one judge stating that *I have started on some Prozac, so I cannot say anything negative*. The judge was in effect saying that he needed medication to be positive about Allan's dancing, which was supposedly so poor that it caused depression. Subsequently, the judge left his seat and walked over to Allan, saying *I'm coming down to you – you stay there*. Next, touching different parts of Allan's body, he physically corrected his movements, simultaneously telling him what he should do with his body. Thus, he moved into Allan's personal space to take control of Allan's body. On top of that, pointing to Allan's feet, he used the repetitive figures of speech *feet to play football with – to play football with*, emphasising the view that Allan's physical features were fundamentally unsuited to dancing. The viewers thus witnessed the judge displaying extremely intimidating behaviour towards Allan. Pointing out Allan's physical flaws in the public sphere in a humiliating and condescending way imparted a very aggressive force to the judge's requests. Another judge patronised Allan by saying that *she feels sorry for his dancing friends because they fall one by one*. The judge thus implied that Allan should feel guilty for being in the show, making him morally responsible for the way the series was developing. As intimidating people by invading their physical space and questioning their moral character are aggressive methods of mobbing, the judges assigned antagonistic emotional force to their requests for social action to remove Allan from the show.

3.3.2. Viewers engaging in language games of mobbing

Some viewers who subscribed to the judges' aggressive methods of mobbing to get Allan out engaged on Facebook to apportion blame to Allan. For example, it was stated that he was destroying the programme for others: *he cannot dance, cannot learn it, has no self-awareness, and ruins the show for those who really can dance* (Dueholm, 13 October). In addition, we saw requests for Allan to withdraw: *It is about DANCE, isn't it! GET OUT, ALLAN!* (Bak, 4 October). The argument for the request for action turns on the claim that *Strictly Come Dancing* is a dancing programme. In other words, these viewers used their emotive wishes as backing for their requests.

Other viewers requesting an entertainment programme engaged in the language game of apportioning blame and attacking the moral character of judges and others. First, some viewers reacted very strongly to the judges' comments, evidently regarding the judges' behaviour as inappropriate: *I cringed on Saturday night ... because of the so-called professional judges' ... perfidious attitudes* (Nørgård, 13 October). The use of phrases such as *so-called professional* and *perfidious attitudes* when describing the judges and their comments points to efforts to intimidate and belittle the judges and to question their professional integrity. The public airing of the *Allan Out* argument also spurred a form of moral indignation, as illustrated in the following extract: *I feel sorry for Allan; everybody picks on him ... I feel bad about this witch hunt* (Sørensen, 28 September). These phrases not only demonstrate empathy with Allan, but also constitute an attack on the moral character of the *Allan Out* group. The viewer continued along the same lines, using imperatives to emphasise that the rules of the game should be followed: *It's a competition, the rules are followed, and Allan is popular. Understand it ... !* (Sørensen, 28 September). According to this argument, because the correct procedures were being followed, it was fair for Allan to remain in the show.

3.3.3. Conclusion: language games of mobbing

On this basis, we can conclude that the TV2 judges initiated a language game of mobbing by personal intimidation to push Allan out of the show, and this was echoed by viewers on social media. One group of viewers subscribed to TV2's method of mobbing, while the other group engaged in a different type of mobbing, attacking the moral character of the judges and viewers who were requesting a dancing programme. The emotive wishes of each group were used as backing for their

requests. Accordingly, TV2 orchestrated mutual mobbing as a method of engaging viewers and controlling the show's development at the operational level.

Viewers engaging in a mobbing group might experience a feeling of excitement and social identity tied to their preferences (van Dijk, 2009), as well as gaining the possibility to exclude those who might be a threat to their value fulfilment and a cause of frustration. Thus, the mutual milieu of mobbing stimulated the antagonistic competitive language game embedded in the formation of the series. As the viewers' engagement in mobbing enabled the creation of the wished-for drama of the series, the viewers were followers of the TV2 language game, not the co-authors of new content. As long as the viewers were engaging in mobbing only, it was likely that the authoritative, calculative language game steered the story of the show towards the interests of TV2. However, around Episode 5, the judges' mobbing did not have the effect of getting Allan out; instead, it escalated and intensified the conflict between TV2 and the *Allan Out* group, on the one side, and the pro-Allan group, on the other side. In fact, some viewers took further action that went beyond engaging in mobbing on the official *Strictly Come Dancing* Facebook site.

3.4. Creating intentional outcomes by ganging up on alternative social webs

This section reveals how some viewers aimed to put in place the factual circumstances that would allow the mobbing language games to lead to the intended results.

3.4.1. Viewers ganging up on alternative social web platforms

Even on the official Facebook site, some viewers attempted to influence TV2 to force Allan to withdraw from the show by stating that they would stop watching the series otherwise. However, a more collective form of pressure to get Allan off the show emerged between Episodes 6 and 7, when a Facebook site called *Get Allan Out* (Ud med Allan) was established.⁶ As the name suggests, the purpose of the Facebook group was to persuade viewers with a shared interest to organise themselves in a participatory website beyond the control of TV2 to bully Allan off the show. The site was inspired by an incident in the UK in which a popular BBC journalist (but poor dancer) was pushed by the TV company into withdrawing from the series.⁷ The number of likes was a way of expressing the buying power of the group, which can be considered a forceful device for putting pressure on TV2 and on Allan to make him withdraw from the show. Indeed, by December 14, 2013, *Get Allan Out* had 48,515 likes, while the official *Strictly Come Dancing* Facebook site had only 34,750 likes.

In opposition to the *Get Allan Out* group, a *Crazy About Allan* Facebook group was created between Episodes 6 and 7 (23 October). Its purpose was to support Allan by ganging up to increase the numbers of pro-Allan votes and thus put pressure on those demanding a dancing programme. The group benefitted from some technological developments. The tabloid paper *Ekstrabladet* invented an 'Allan Alarm' that said 'Do you also want to help Allan get to the top with your voting? Sign up for the *Ekstrabladet* SMS service that will help you remember when to send your vote for Allan'. This call to action was accompanied by a hyperlink to the alarm widget on the newspaper's website.⁸ Other viewers created an 'Allan App' that made it easier to vote. These services also made it possible for 'phantom' viewers who did not even watch the programme to cast votes; thus, viewers who might be fans of Allan but not of the programme had the possibility to cast votes. In addition, we can see comments on the *Crazy About Allan* Facebook site from another type of 'phantom' viewer: people who did not watch *Strictly Come Dancing* but were evidently voting for Allan in the hope of destroying the programme. The following quote illustrates this: *The reason I vote for Allan is to destroy the bourgeois shitty programme* (Sørensen, 23 October). As is evident in the use of terms such as *bourgeois shitty*, this viewer did not find the programme culturally stimulating. In other words, two types of phantom viewers engaged in authoring language play with a view to creating a new language game to run the *Strictly Come Dancing* drama.

As *Crazy About Allan* sympathisers cast votes as a means of protesting against the mobbing of Allan or the overall programme profile of TV2, the group was able to mobilise people with values dissimilar to their own. The *Crazy About Allan* site became successful, and by December 14, 2013 had 64,007 likes, almost one-third as many again as the *Get Allan Out* site. If the number of likes were to be reflected in the votes cast, Allan would be likely to come first in the viewers' ranking, and this would keep him from entering the dance-off before the semi-final stage.

3.4.2. Conclusion: ganging up

While the *Get Allan Out* group ganged up on alternative participatory platforms to put pressure on TV2 to withdraw Allan from the show, the *Crazy About Allan* group ganged up with groups of 'phantom' viewers and thereby disrupted the calculative measurement models that ran the development of the show. In effect, the *Crazy About Allan* group was able to put in place the factual circumstances for a new language game aimed at creating a storyline in which the 'sore thumb' might become the

⁶ <https://www.facebook.com/pages/UD-MED-ALLAN/224965357664926?fref=ts>, 21 October 2013.

⁷ <http://news.bbc.co.uk/2/hi/entertainment/7737447.stm>.

⁸ See <http://ekstrabladet.dk/flash/filmogtv/tv/article4582516.ece>, 31 October 2013. We witnessed competing requests from the media. The hosts of a Danish satirical radio programme ('The Boys from Monte Carlo') encouraged their more than half a million listeners to trigger an SMS storm by texting votes for Allan Simonsen (<http://www.bt.dk/vild-med-dans/monte-carlo-gaa-sms-amok-paa-allan-simonsen>). However, other news media encouraged the audience to vote for other couples and not for Allan (see <http://www.b.dk/kommentarer/simonseeeeee>).

winner (Bonner, 2013). In other words, they were engaged in authoring and setting up a new language game to run the development of the show; they became creators of content. In this way, the antagonistic conflicts among viewers and between some of the viewers and the judges escalated, and a series ending within the identifying marks of the *Strictly Come Dancing* brand was under threat.

3.5. Creating intentional outcomes by means of an ad hoc ruling

As we explain below, TV2 took action to forestall the prospect of the 'sore thumb' of the show becoming its winner.

3.5.1. TV2 engaging in an ad hoc ruling

During Episode 9, TV2 altered the SMS voting system without warning. They changed the identifying initials of the couples, which had remained constant during the previous episodes, and they reduced the number of votes permissible per person, previously unlimited, to five. The programme manager argued that the change in the rules had been implemented to limit the number of votes cast by people who had not seen the show, emphasising that the show was produced for its viewers: 'This season, we have seen that *Strictly Come Dancing* has reached far beyond the viewers of the show ... it is important for us as an organisation to send a message to the people who support the show – that they are the ones we're doing the show for.' This indicated a slippage in the meaning of the term 'viewers' that enabled TV2 to implement a change in the voting system with the intention of controlling the audience. As mentioned above, the change of auction rules through the voting system was substantial enough to require the approval of the licence owners, the BBC.

Despite the new auction rules, Allan reached the semi-finals in Episode 11, although he received too few votes to reach the final. In Episode 11, there were technical problems in relation to the voting. The mobile network was down for about 45 min, which meant fewer possibilities to vote for the last dancer, who was Allan. Nevertheless, the programme manager stated that they had consulted with two mobile phone companies on the distribution of votes, and on that basis, they concluded that even if the lost text messages had been received, the outcome would not have been different.

So, in the end, the *Get Allan Out* group was able to put in place the factual circumstances for their language game to lead to their intended result.⁹ However, some of the Allan supporters thought that the mobile network breakdown was a deliberate attempt by TV2 to manipulate the results (Henriksen, 25 November). This suspicion prompted one of the co-founders of the *Crazy About Allan* Facebook group to file a report with the police. In February 2014, the police decided to close the investigation.

In the terms of auction theory, TV2 constrained the possibilities for bidders to influence the development of the show. In so doing, they engaged in a language game of ad hoc rulings, involving slippage in the core concept of 'viewers' in the participatory measurement system, and a cover-up concerning who had and had not been able to vote. Ultimately, the saga shows that TV2 remained committed to its own vision of a winner but had to break with the previous practice of the language rules of the customer participatory measurement system.

3.5.2. Conclusion: ad hoc ruling

When its vision of a winner was threatened, TV2 changed the language game of the auction model by creating new voting rules that made the participatory measurement system produce an ending consistent with the identifying marks of the *Strictly Come Dancing* brand. Thus, TV2 destroyed the pragmatics of the established language rules that governed the show, but they gained control of the directional force of the authoritative calculative system. By changing the measurement rules, they were crowding out the phantom votes disrupting the calculative measurement models. In conclusion, TV2 was not able to embrace viewers aiming to create new content for the winning character.

3.6. Conclusion: methods of performance management and types of co-creator

Our analysis reveals that *Strictly Come Dancing* began by promising that viewers would have an influence on the development of the show through social media and SMS voting, suggesting that a kind of consumer democracy would govern the development of the series. In this way, the show set expectations on the part of the viewers that their wishes would be fulfilled, which might motivate them to engage in the show.

Furthermore, we found that TV2's customer participatory performance management practice was run by an emotive, antagonistic competitive language game. In fact, the formation of the show was constructed around the polarised requests of two groups of viewers and an auction model offering calculative ratings and rankings of emotive expressions of requests with a view to categorising, differentiating, and excluding all couples one by one, leaving only the highest-ranked couple. This implies that it was impossible to integrate the values of all groups of viewers into the final outcome of the series. Nevertheless, competition can create feelings of excitement that might be the motivational values ensuring that some viewers engaged in SMS voting and on social media. By ranking and excluding requests, the participatory measurement model will have induced negative rewarding experiences among viewers, thereby creating an emotive milieu of frustrations and aggressions and propelling their engagement (Heron, 1992; L. Nørreklit, 2017b). Indeed, we observed that viewers felt entitled to engage

⁹ See https://www.facebook.com/vildmeddands/posts/10152028003026683?comment_id=28930659&offset=0&total_comments=147.

fiercely when their subjective desires were not being fulfilled by TV2. They went into the affective mode of aggressive mobbing, which was amplified by the judges' own mobbing tactics. The situation was exacerbated by the tendency of the social media comments to leave out social-ethical filtering. The very nature of mobbing is that it is an emotional form of communication that divides and hence stimulates the antagonistic competitive language game embedded in the auction model.

When emotive, antagonistic competitive language games interact, the outcome is unpredictable, and so was the development of the series in this case. However, since TV2 had a significant say in the results, it was always likely to be able to control the development and final outcome of the series. Thus, embedded in the calculative system was a strong centripetal force towards excluding everyone except those whom TV2 thought were the best. Consequently, the emotive, antagonistic competitive language game worked in combination with a language game of an authoritative calculative system. While the emotive, antagonistic competitive language games created viewer engagement with the show, the authoritative language game carried out a meaning structure with the force to control the story so that it would gradually unfold, reaching a climax around Episode 5 and then fading out (Bonner, 2013). In this case, the drama of *Strictly Come Dancing* did not peak before the semi-final, because some viewers were able to undermine the projected outcome of the calculative system by making 'phantom' viewers cast votes, thus breaking the authoritative force of the requests made via the system. The usual pattern of *Strictly Come Dancing* did not involve a change in the rules of the calculative system; however, when the vision of a 'happy ending' outcome was threatened, TV2 made an ad hoc ruling to gain control of the directional force of the authoritative calculative system to produce the intended outcome.

On this basis, we conclude that an emotive, antagonistic competitive language game and an authoritative calculative language game together governed the customer participative measurement practice of TV2. The emotive, antagonistic language game was able to create viewer engagement and induce a feeling of consumer democracy, while the authoritative language game carried out a meaning structure with a centripetal force towards the voice of TV2. Accordingly, we witnessed an illusion of consumer democracy, where emotive linking to the actors' values worked instrumentally to create the illusion. In this case, the ad hoc ruling made it clear that the democratic participation was an illusion.

Many viewers engaged in the show through voting and mobbing on the TV2 social Web. These viewers were mainly providers of low-level cognitive data input for running the drama of the show; they engaged in the emotive and polarised language game that ran the show, and hence they were followers of TV2 language games rather than creators of content. However, a few viewers managed to become reflective and creative actors, searching for possibilities to take action that would prevent the force of the calculative system from excluding Allan. They used alternative platforms and voting technologies to enable other actors to go along with them, thereby creating new content for the drama. However, in the end, TV2 could not embrace these viewers aiming to create new content for the winning character.

One might argue that the few innovative actors did not engage in authoring language play with a view to developing a program of mutual beneficial value, but rather to sabotage the *Strictly Come Dancing* brand (Kähr, Nyffenegger, Krohmer, & Hoyer, 2016). Thus, rather than aiming to help Allan win, their actions might have been focused on spoiling the program. These 'viewers' engaged in brand sabotage in order to be seen as having deliberately commenced the construction of activities aimed at spoiling other viewers' positive experiences of the program, and hence to harm the value of the brand. Brand sabotage might begin when products or services induce negative experiences among their customers, or are in conflict with more general values of (non)customers. Customers who have negative experiences will often be motivated to engage constructively to improve their value fulfilment without obstructing the brand; however, other (non)customers might want to interact to sabotage the brand (Kähr et al., 2016). Driven by hostile, principle-inspired mindsets, brand saboteurs might invest significant effort and creativity to activate dissatisfied consumers as instrumental aggressors to harm or even destroy the brand. Drawing on emotive, antagonistic competitive language games to engage viewers, the *Strictly Come Dancing* show format seems exposed to such sabotage; nevertheless, TV2 appeared able to deal with the sabotage through ad hoc ruling.

4. Discussion and conclusions

The current research has explored which methods of performance management governed TV2's practice of customer participatory measurement and which types of co-creating viewers engaged in the programme. Our analysis reveals that TV2's customer participatory performance management practice was run by an emotive, antagonistic competitive language game and an authoritative calculative language game that operated in cooperation. TV2 created an expectation of consumer democracy and made the viewers engage in the show while simultaneously controlling the drama so that it would unfold in ways that reflected the voice of the television company. Through mobbing and voting, many viewers engaged in producing the information required to run the drama, following the language game of the show. However, in this case, viewers who wanted the 'sore thumb' to win, or to harm the show, were able to undermine the calculative system by establishing alternative platforms and voting technologies to make 'phantom' viewers cast votes. These viewers stood out as innovative actors breaking the authoritative force in the calculative system to gain more influence on the development of the show; thus, they were creators of content, and possibly brand saboteurs. To gain control of the ending of the drama, TV2 applied an ad hoc ruling, which breached the pragmatics of a well-established rule of the show and accentuated the illusory nature of the

democratic participation. Thus, *Strictly Come Dancing* embraced viewers who were followers of content but was unable to embrace those who were creators of content.

The study provides novel insights into how companies might produce and use customer participatory measurement systems as an integrated part of their customer participatory logic of value co-creation. It extends the toolkit of performance management by revealing techniques and methods used within an emotive competitive language game and an authoritative calculative language game, and identifying how these might operate in cooperation for organisational control in a user participatory context. The study also reveals insights into potential (non-)intentional effects of using such language games of participatory performance management.

Our findings confirm that end users engaging in co-creation can provide information input without creating content, as the end user intervention is to a large extent defined by the organisation (van Dijck, 2009). In fact, authoritative calculative language games implanted with coded mechanisms and algorithms are widely used by organisations to steer users towards particular goals (O'Neil, 2016; van Dijck, 2009). In addition, the antagonistic competitive auction model can be a dominating mechanism that governs an organisation's interaction with its participatory customers. For instance, an antagonistic competitive auction model is embedded in the Google search engine, although the organisation of the coalition of participants and the rules around ranking are different from those in *Strictly Come Dancing* (Bar-Ilan, 2007; van Dijck, 2009; Varian, 2007). The underlying algorithms of the Google rankings are complex and secret, but the language game involves one of the bidders competing to determine the best ranking among a selection of service offers while excluding others. Another example is provided by the contours of the auction model in IT-based measurement systems used for the performance evaluation of university scholars, which steer researchers in certain directions (Nørreklit et al., 2019).

At first glance, our findings contrast with those of studies on TripAdvisor traveller ratings and rankings, which found that hotels and restaurants seem to have been coerced into reacting and responding to reviews (Jeacle & Carter, 2011; Scott & Orlikowski, 2012). Thus, the customer participatory measurement of TripAdvisor might in fact lead to the improvement of hotel and restaurant services. However, hotels and restaurants do not control the TripAdvisor customer measurement system. Nevertheless, our study confirms that organisations operating in a context influenced by social media cannot disregard the voice of the customer (Scott & Orlikowski, 2012). For instance, the ganging-up behaviour we identified is consistent with other research on organisations using customer involvement through online innovation communities, which found that dissatisfied customers may trigger negative word-of-mouth and become anti-brand communities that can ultimately cause an organisation to lose control of its service development and brand (Fisk et al., 2010; Gebauer, Fuller, & Pezzeri, 2013; Kähr et al., 2016). Customers can be very active in communicating with each other in social networks outside the organisational space of power to organise a counterpower that might help them put pressure on organisations to further some of their desires (Mangold & Faulds, 2009). In addition, customers may engage in activities that influence rankings, such as search engine manipulation or false postings and 'likes' (Bar-Ilan, 2007; Jeacle & Carter, 2011). However, users and site's owners might not be able to see this manipulation (Horton, 2017). In general, 'rankings and ratings are vulnerable to manipulation, both by users and by the site's owners' (van Dijck, 2009, p. 45), but ultimately, the one in control of the algorithm shapes the ranking and hence the action (O'Neil, 2016).

The milieu of aggressive mobbing appears to govern many social Web platforms (Bertolotti & Magnani, 2013); however, the problem might have been aggravated in the case considered in this paper by the mechanical production and use of customer participatory measurement. Emphatic insights and engagement with others require detailed semantic knowledge and subjective grounds, which contrasts with the low level of cognition that is required to be a co-creator through SMS voting. Also, in terms of the number, using the reductive language of ranking leaves out the subjective grounds and in no sense encourages empathic awareness of the subjective grounds or social-ethical filtering. Furthermore, when a practice is run only by emotion-driven ratings and an authoritative calculative system there is no interactive and reflective reasoning to establish general conditions of truth to govern the social interaction (Nørreklit et al., 2019; Nørreklit, 2013). Without conditions of truth power and emotions wins, while ethics do not exist. Overall, mechanical production and use of reductive measurement may foster the individual actor's deindividuation, wherein their feelings of empathy, social values, and ethical responsibility fade (Postmes & Spears, 1998). Deindividuation has been strongly correlated with aggressive crowds and mobbing behaviours, and hence polarisation in social relationships.

In addition, the paper reveals that by studying a user participatory measurement system through the theory of pragmatic constructivism and the network of language games producing and using the system, one can get 'inside' organisational participatory business practices to obtain insights into their performance management methods and the level of content invention they allow for. Thus, the point of departure of the pragmatic constructivist approach to understanding language games is the reality construction of the actors of a given organisational practice, and not, as per some dominating sociological scholars (Foucault, 1969; Giddens, 2013), how meta-structures of linguistic practices outside local practices – meta-language games – can govern local language games, and hence local agencies and practices (see also H. Nørreklit, 2017a). In view of the fact that the language construction of organisational actors must integrate all four dimensions of reality in a situated and original manner, if they are to construct a pragmatically functioning organisation, the emergence and justification of performance measurement in local organisational practice is to be analysed according to the way in which the language games, that are giving meaning to the measures, form and deform integration of the four dimensions of the reality construction. The unique case of *Strictly Come Dancing* provides direct insight into the language games that produced and used the customer participatory measurement system in a specific manner.

A challenge of the pragmatic constructivist approach is developing concepts by which to analyse and understand the language games of the specific organisational practice and the (dys)functional reality constructions they create. Our study adds to the methodological apparatus for analysing, conceptualising, and understanding language games of performance management in a specific customer participatory business context. The methodological apparatus provides an understanding of the network of language games that produced and used the participatory measurement system in a way that meaningfully explains the developments of the case (Arbnor & Bjerke, 1997). Our case is unique as we were able to observe and gain insights into the way in which customer participatory measurement systems were produced and used as the events evolved. Although we did not, of course, have access to the private thoughts of the actors involved in the production of the programme, we do believe that basing the study on such publicly accessible communication still leads to a profound understanding.

Our study provides insights into the performance management practice of a specific milieu of customer participatory measurement facilitated by Web 2.0 technologies. As the features and procedures of the reality television talent programme are context-specific, the findings are not directly applicable to other practices, but should be used in reflective interaction with the specific practice context in question (Nørreklit et al., 2016). Above, we suggest similarities to other cases of user participatory measurement systems facilitated by the social Web, and, by providing descriptions of our context, we hope to enable the reader to assess where generalisation into other contexts can, and cannot, be justified (see e.g. Nørreklit et al., 2016). We call for more research on the language games driving participatory measurement systems in other contexts, their ability to integrate end users as co-creators of content, and the ways in which organisations and users can act mutually beneficially to co-create content in a participatory measurement culture. Finally, as the methods for conceptualising the (non) integration of the four dimensions of reality are in a nascent stage, further research on this issue is required. There is a clear need to enhance our conceptualisation of the variety of (dys)functional reality constructions of our participatory society.

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